

Glossary — Vocabulary Trainer

311 terms from LitCult (Poetry · Drama · Narrative · Film) and English Linguistics.

How to drill: cover one column with a sheet of paper. Pass 1: read the definition, say and WRITE the term — that is the exam direction. Pass 2: cover the definitions, define each term aloud. Mark failures, repeat only those.

Poetry	
Meter	Pattern of stressed and unstressed syllables, defined by kind and number of feet
Rhythm	Meter plus its linguistic and stylistic realisation in the verse
Iamb	Foot x / (be-LOW)
Trochee	Foot / x (GAR-den)
Spondee	Foot / / (HEART-BREAK)
Dactyl	Foot / x x (MER-ri-ly)
Anapest	Foot x x / (in-ter-VENE)
Pentameter	Line of five feet; iambic pentameter is the English staple
Blank verse	Unrhymed iambic pentameter
Alexandrine	Iambic hexameter line
Free verse	Poetry without meter, rhyme or fixed stanza
End-stopped line	Syntax pauses where the line ends
Enjambment	Sentence runs over the line break (run-on line)
Caesura	Metrical break inside a line
End-rhyme	Rhyme at line endings
Internal rhyme	Rhyme inside a line
Eye-rhyme	Looks alike, sounds different (far/war)
Half-rhyme	Similar sound, no full rhyme (jeer/there)
Masculine rhyme	One-syllable rhyme, final syllable stressed
Feminine rhyme	Two or more syllables, unstressed ending
Identical rhyme	The same word rhymed with itself
Alternate rhyme	Scheme abab (cross rhyme)
Enclosing rhyme	Scheme abba (embracing rhyme)
Chain rhyme	Scheme aba bcb (interlocking)
Tail rhyme	Scheme aab ccb
Couplet	Two rhyming lines; heroic couplet = in iambic pentameter
Quatrain	Four-line stanza
Tercet	Three-line stanza
Sestet	Six-line unit; the Petrarchan sonnet's second part
Octave	Eight-line unit; the Petrarchan sonnet's first part
Shakespearean sonnet	Three quatrains plus couplet, abab cdcd efef gg

Petrarchan sonnet	Octave plus sestet, volta at line 9
Villanelle	19 lines, five tercets plus quatrain, two rhymes, two alternating refrains
Ballad	Narrative poem in song-like stanzas
Ode	Elevated poem of praise or meditation
Elegy	Poem of mourning
Volta	The rhetorical turn of a sonnet
Simile	Explicit comparison using like or as
Metaphor	Implicit comparison: one thing described as another
Conceit	Extended, elaborate metaphor sustained through a passage or poem
Metonymy	Attribute stands for the thing (the Crown)
Synecdoche	Part stands for the whole (all hands)
Symbol	Concrete thing standing for an abstract idea beyond itself
Personification	Human traits given to the non-human
Apostrophe	Direct address to an absent, abstract or non-answering addressee
Oxymoron	Contradictory words fused (cultured hell)
Paradox	Self-contradictory statement containing truth
Hyperbole	Exaggeration for emphasis
Euphemism	Mild term for a harsh reality; opposite: dysphemism
Anaphora	Repetition at the start of successive clauses
Epiphora	Repetition at the end of successive clauses (epistrophe)
Ellipsis (rhetoric)	Omission of words recoverable from context
Pun	Play on a word's double meaning
Allegory	Story readable on a surface and an under-the-surface level
Speaker / lyric I	The constructed voice of a poem; never simply the poet

Drama

Dramatic text	The play as verbal sign-system only
Theatrical performance	The play realised through many sign systems on stage
Internal communication	Character to character, inside the play
External communication	Text: author to reader; performance: production to audience
Discrepant awareness	Audience and characters know different things
Dramatic irony	The audience knows more than the characters
Isolated exposition	Context given outside the action (prologue)
Integrated exposition	Context revealed inside the unfolding action
Dialogue	Speech between characters; verbal action driving the plot
Monologue	Long speech others can hear; subjective, not automatically reliable
Soliloquy	Speech alone on stage; honest and reliable

Aside	Line the other characters on stage cannot hear
Dramatis personae	The cast of characters of a play
Foil	Contrast figure sharpening a protagonist's profile
Confidant(e)	Trusted listener enabling self-revelation on stage
Constellation	Structural web of relations between all characters
Configuration	The set of characters on stage in a given scene
Explicit characterisation	What is said about a character (by self or others)
Implicit characterisation	Shown through appearance, body language, entrances, voice
Five-act structure	Exposition, complication, climax, reversal, catastrophe
Three unities	Neoclassical demand: unity of action, place and time
Open form	Drama violating the three unities
Word scenery	Setting evoked through language instead of set design
Apron stage	Elizabethan stage surrounded by spectators on three sides
Picture-frame stage	Modern indoor stage behind a proscenium
Fourth wall	Imaginary boundary between stage and audience
Quarto	Early single-play printing; Q1 of R&J; (1597) is a bad quarto
First Folio	The 1623 collected edition of Shakespeare's plays
Tragedy	From prosperity to adversity; noble hero, flaw, fall
Comedy	From adversity to prosperity; ordinary people, mirror of society
Hamartia	The hero's error of judgment
Hubris	Overweening pride as tragic flaw
Anagnorisis	The hero's tragic recognition
Catharsis	The audience's purging of pity and fear
Tragicomedy	Serious conflict mixed with light-hearted elements
Comedy of manners	Wit-driven comedy of social sophistication
Epic drama	Narrative elements invade the stage (narrator figure)

Narrative

Story	WHAT is told: events, characters, setting
Discourse	HOW it is told: the mediation of the story
Narrativity	What makes a text a narrative: story-based, discourse-based, or experientiality
Experientiality	Fludernik: narrativity as represented lived experience
Narrator	The fictive voice that tells; never the real author
Narratee	The addressee built into the text
Heterodiegetic narrator	Absent from the story he tells
Homodiegetic narrator	Present as a character in the story told
Autodiegetic narrator	Homodiegetic narrator who is the protagonist

Extradiegetic level	First level: the narrating act itself
Intradiegetic level	Everything narrated: characters and events
Metadiegetic level	A story told by an intradiegetic character
Frame narrative	A story wrapped around an embedded main story
Focalisation	Restriction of narrative information: who perceives
Zero focalisation	Narrator knows and says more than any character
Internal focalisation	Restricted to one character's perception (fixed, variable, multiple)
External focalisation	Surface only; no access to minds
Authorial narrative situation	Stanzel: omniscient, omnipresent, commenting narrator
Figural narrative situation	Stanzel: events filtered through a reflector character
First-person narrative situation	Stanzel: narrator inside the narrated world
Reflector character	Consciousness through which figural narration is filtered
Unreliable narrator	A narrating voice the text teaches us to distrust
Subsequent narration	Telling after the events (classic past tense)
Prior narration	Predictive telling before the events
Simultaneous narration	Telling while events happen (present tense)
Interpolated narration	Telling between the moments of action (diary, letters)
Narrating vs experiencing I	Older telling self vs younger living self
Setting	Fictional places giving the storyworld its topology
Path / portal / container	Spatial concepts: routes, transitions, inside-outside
Atmosphere	Mood generated by the depiction of space

Film

Mise-en-scene	Everything visible, arranged before filming
Set	Constructed setting, often on a soundstage
Prop	Object functioning in the scene
Blocking	Arrangement and movement of actors in space
Character actor	Actor associated with a recurring type
Star	Actor carrying aura and audience recognition
Natural lighting	Light from a source within the scene
Directional lighting	Light shaped from outside to sculpt the image
Cinematography	The art and technique of film photography
Shot	Continuous point of view without a cut
Subjective POV	Camera recreates a character's perception
Male gaze	Cultural convention shaping the supposedly neutral camera
Framing	What the rectangular frame includes and excludes
Offscreen space	The world implied beyond the frame

Establishing shot	Opening long shot that sets spatial context
Close-up	Face or detail fills the frame
Medium shot	Human figure from the waist up
Long shot	Full figure to landscape distance
Pan	Frame swivels; camera position fixed
Tracking shot	Camera itself travels through space
Zoom	Lens adjusts focal length; no camera movement
Cut	Direct join between two shots
Fade	Image darkens to black (out) or emerges from it (in)
Dissolve	One shot superimposed over the next
Wipe	A moving line replaces one shot with another
Continuity editing	Invisible Hollywood style creating seamless space and time
Disjunctive editing	Deliberate breaks of continuity for effect
180-degree rule	Keep the camera on one side of the axis of action
Shot-reverse-shot	Alternating angles across a conversation
Eyeline match	Look offscreen, cut to what is seen
Insert	Detail shot cut into a scene
Crosscutting	Alternating actions to suggest simultaneity
Flashback / flashforward	Shots of past or future interrupting the present
Pace	Editing rhythm: length of takes before each cut
Intradiegetic sound	Sound from within the storyworld
Extradiegetic sound	Score and voice-over outside the storyworld
Sound bridge	Sound carrying across a cut or diegesis border
Genre conventions	Recurring settings, types and iconography defining a film genre
Period drama	Genre staging the national past: estates, costume, literary sources

Linguistics · Basics

Linguistics	The scientific study of language structure and use
Sign (Saussure)	Arbitrary union of signifier and signified
Signifier	The sound image of the sign
Signified	The concept of the sign
Arbitrariness	No natural bond between form and meaning
Onomatopoeia	Marginal motivated signs imitating sounds
Semiotic triangle	Symbol, thought, referent (Ogden and Richards)
Langue	The shared sign system in the mind
Parole	Concrete individual language use
Langage	The inborn human language capacity
Competence / performance	Chomsky's knowledge vs use distinction

Synchronic	Language at one point in time
Diachronic	Language across time
Descriptive	Recording what speakers do
Prescriptive	Decreeing what speakers should do

Linguistics · Phonology

Phonetics	Physical study of speech sounds: articulatory, acoustic, auditory
Phonology	System of meaningful sound contrasts of a language
Phone	Any concrete speech sound []
Phoneme	Smallest meaning-distinguishing unit / /
Allophone	Contextual or free variant of a phoneme
Minimal pair	Word pair differing in exactly one sound
Complementary distribution	Variants bound each to its own context
Place of articulation	Where the airstream is shaped (bilabial to glottal)
Manner of articulation	How: plosive, fricative, affricate, nasal, lateral, approximant
Voicing	Vocal cord vibration distinguishing sound pairs
Syllable	Onset plus rhyme (nucleus plus coda)
Phonotactics	Rules for permissible sound combinations
Maximum onset principle	Assign consonants to the following onset where legal
Word stress	Fixed prominence distinguishing words (REcord/reCORD)
Vowel reduction	Unstressed vowels drift to schwa
Weak forms	Reduced grammatical words in connected speech
Assimilation	Neighbouring sounds becoming more alike
Intonation	Pitch movement over utterances; tones carry meaning
Tonic syllable	The syllable carrying the tone movement
Final devoicing	German Auslautverhaertung; source of learner errors

Linguistics · Morphology

Morpheme	Smallest meaningful unit
Free morpheme	Stands alone: lexical or grammatical
Bound morpheme	Only attached: derivational or inflectional
Allomorph	Phonetic variant of one morpheme
Base / stem	What derivation / inflection attaches to
Productivity	How freely an affix creates new words
Compounding	Two free morphemes; head on the right
Endocentric compound	A kind of its head (apple pie)
Exocentric compound	Head unexpressed (paleface)

Copulative compound	Both parts apply (bittersweet)
Appositional compound	Two descriptions, one referent (actor-director)
Derivation	Free plus bound derivational morpheme
Conversion	New word class without formal change (zero-derivation)
Clipping	Deleting material (gym)
Blending	Fusing beginnings and ends (motel)
Acronym	Initials pronounced as a word (NATO)
Alphabetism	Initials spelt letter by letter (FBI)
Back-formation	Removing a supposed affix (edit from editor)

Linguistics · Syntax

Phrase	Words united around a head (NP, VP, PP, AdjP, AdvP)
Constituent	Any unit functioning as a block in structure
Phrase tests	Substitution, movement, coordination, stand-alone
Structural ambiguity	One string, two bracketings, two meanings
Valency	The verb dictates its obligatory slots
Subject / object / complement / adverbial	Grammatical functions, independent of form
Seven clause patterns	SP, SPO, SPCS, SPA, SPOO, SPOCO, SPOA
Passivisation test	Objects become passive subjects; adverbials do not
Clause types	Relative, adverbial, nominal subordinate clauses
Sentence types	Simple, compound, complex
Synthetic language	Grammar packed into inflection (Latin) or agglutination (Turkish)
Analytic language	Grammar via word order and function words
Autosemantic / synsemantic	Content words vs function words

Linguistics · Semantics

Semantics	Study of conventional, de-contextualised meaning
Lexeme	Abstract dictionary word covering all its forms
Lemma	The headword of a dictionary entry
Lexicology / lexicography	Studying the vocabulary / writing dictionaries
Compositionality	Complex meaning as sum of parts (Frege); idioms resist it
Idiom	Expression whose meaning exceeds its parts
Componential analysis	Meaning as feature bundles [+human][-adult]
Prototype	Best exemplar organising a fuzzy category
Reference / sense	Word-world relation vs word-defining properties
Extension / intension	Class of referents vs set of defining features
Denotation / connotation	Objective core vs emotional layer

Polysemy	One form, related senses (beam)
Homonymy	One form, unrelated meanings (mole)
Synonymy	Same sense; total synonymy near-nonexistent
Antonymy	Complementary, gradable, or relational opposites
Hyperonym / hyponym	Superordinate vs subordinate term (dog / terrier)
Holonym / meronym	Whole vs part (car / windscreen)
Lexical field	Set of lexemes covering one domain
Collocation	Habitual word partnership (do homework)

Linguistics · Pragmatics

Pragmatics	Meaning of utterances in context
Utterance	Concrete realisation of a sentence in situation
Organon model	Buehler: expression, representation, appeal
Jakobson's functions	Emotive, conative, referential, phatic, metalinguistic, poetic
Speech act	Doing things with words (Austin, Searle)
Phonetic / phatic / rhetic act	Producing sounds / ordered words / meaningful use
Proposition	The literal content of an utterance
Illocution	The speaker's intention in uttering
Perlocution	The effect achieved in the listener
Representative	Speech act claiming truth
Directive	Speech act getting the hearer to act
Commissive	Speaker commits to future action
Expressive	Speaker displays an attitude
Declaration	The utterance changes the world
Indirect speech act	Form and function diverge (Can you pass the salt?)
Performative	Verb that does the act in saying it (hereby-test)
Deixis	Expressions anchored in context: person, place, time
Cooperative principle	Grice: assume purposeful, rule-guided conversation
Maxims	Quality, quantity, relevance, manner
Conversational implicature	Inferred meaning generated by flouting; cancellable
Conventional implicature	Meaning glued to a word itself (but, even)
Theme / rheme	Given information vs new information
End focus / end weight	New and heavy material gravitates to clause end
Discourse marker	Signal structuring speech units

Linguistics · Socio

Sociolinguistics	Language as a social phenomenon
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Diatopic / diastratic / diaphasic	Regional / social / situational variation
Dialect	Variety differing in pronunciation, vocabulary and grammar
Accent	Variety differing in pronunciation only
Sociolect	Variety of a social group (jargon, genderlect)
Register	Variety fitted to the situation
Standard variety	The socially victorious dialect; overt prestige
Covert prestige	Value attached to stigmatised varieties
Vernacular	Variety furthest from the educated standard
Accommodation	Convergence towards or divergence from interlocutors
Labov's NYC study	Class and formality correlate with prestige /r/
Hypercorrection	Lower middle class overshooting the norm
AAVE	Systematic variety: copula deletion, multiple negation
Apparent time	Age differences read as change in progress

Linguistics · History

Internal change	Ease of articulation, symmetry, analogy, reanalysis
External change	Contact, separation, cultural and social change
Analogy	Regular patterns extended to irregular forms
Reanalysis	Misparsed boundaries create new forms (an adder)
Spelling pronunciation	Pronunciation follows the written form (often)
Indo-European	The reconstructed ancestor family of English
West Germanic	English's branch, with Frisian, Dutch, German
Second consonant shift	High German shift: pound/Pfund, ship/Schiff
Old English	c. 500-1100; synthetic, four dialects, Beowulf
Middle English	c. 1100-1500; inflection loss, French influx, Chaucer
Early Modern English	c. 1500-1750; GVS, printing, codification, Shakespeare
Great Vowel Shift	All ME long vowels raised or diphthongised
Do-periphrasis	Optional in EModE, obligatory later
Danelaw	Norse settlement zone; everyday Norse loans
Synthetic to analytic	English's long drift from endings to word order

Linguistics · World

Pluricentric	A language with several interacting standards
ENL / ESL / EFL	Native, second and foreign language Englishes
ELF	English as lingua franca between non-natives
Kachru's circles	Inner (norm-providing), Outer (developing), Expanding (dependent)
New Englishes	Postcolonial second-language varieties

Diaspora (first/second)	Settler colonies vs exploitation colonies
Rhoticity	Post-vocalic /r/ sounded (AmE) or silent (BrE)
T-flapping	AmE better with a flapped [d]-like t
Isogloss	Boundary line of a single feature
Dialect boundary	Bundle of overlapping isoglosses
Northern Cities Shift	Ongoing US Great Lakes vowel rotation
Scots	Dialect with its own literary tradition (Burns)